



## The Cambrian explosion

A study on how plants and fungi primed the planet to make the Cambrian explosion possible. <https://digit.in/may20-87>



## Write as a hivemind

How to write in first person perspective of a hivemind? Avoid "we". It can be confused with the "royal we". <https://digit.in/may20-88>

bombarding the rocky worlds. Almost as soon as these colliding comets donated reservoirs of water to the inner planets, we took hold, and the star became host to the first of us. The young planet had only gone around the star 40 million times, and we began to use the hydrothermal vents as an energy source almost as soon as the liquid oceans were formed. We began to communicate with each other, strengthen the incipient hivemind on this planet through our rich organic compound signals, the production of which we carried in our life strands. Every step we took from then on was a planned and calculated move towards the endgame, the sporting event that would take place when the star died.

### 3 BILLION YEARS

We had to wait patiently while the rock cooled. During this time, we spread across the planet, laying down the foundations for our plan. The great plates beneath the ground formed, but there were still massive traps, volcanoes from which the molten rock from within the planet poured out. For a billion years, we primed the planet for the drones, using tiny unicellular factories that pumped out the gas that formed the fuel for the robots. Prototype versions of the drones, that used a simpler fuel, suffocated in hordes because of the accumulation of the gas in the atmosphere. We have used some inhospitable planets as laboratories to allow these prototype anaerobic machines to multiply as they pleased. The scientist aspect had gotten frustrated with the lack of intelligent life apart from us, and wanted to check if intelligence could emerge given free reign on a planet. It didn't and there have been no follow up experiments for over 10 billion years since.

### 4 BILLION YEARS

This was the most critical part of the life cycle, one where a number of factors have to be balanced to get

everything just right. It involved rolling out a massive carpet to cover the entire planet, a process that we started in the bottom of the ocean. The blades covered the land and pumped out even more gas into the atmosphere. The gas then dissolved into the seas in large amounts, which allowed for the drones to flourish and thrive. This was followed by a veritable explosion of creation, a multitude of drone forms, as if the box of drone templates was opened up. Then, the hardy devourer droids, incredibly long lived variants that decomposed everything in their vicinity, spread over the ground, breaking up the carbon and the calcium stored within the rocks. These elements then enter the seas too, in large quantities, allowing the drones to protect themselves better from the harsh environments that their future iterations might find themselves in. The drones were self replicating, and are programmed to continually adapt to their environments. The elements allowed the drones to build hardy interior and exterior support structures. In this single diversification, we produced a variety of drones from a single template. They all had various numbers of appendages, from four to over a hundred, and within them, they had what was necessary to carry on our work all over the planet.

### 4.5 BILLION YEARS

The artist and the gardener designed self replicating jewel cases in a thousand shades and aromas. These were peppered throughout the planet, for decoration. They were designed to be bright and attractive to many of the drones, and served the function of providing them with fuel. The drones meanwhile, became increasingly sophisticated. They had minds, but each one had their own, isolated from all others, a seemingly insurmountable gulf that took iterations to bridge. These minds were localised in the crown cases of the creatures, and they could not directly communicate with each other. We needed to

allow these minds to talk, and one of the ways to do it is to send our buds on cow dung. These chemical compounds allow us to communicate to the drones by planting visions of the future and the past. Many a mind was just broken by these visions, but those that survived managed to spread the knowledge. It was at this time itself, that the self destruction protocols were programmed into them, so that they would not spread uncontrollably. If left unchecked, these drones can become pests, consuming the resources that we need so sorely for our colonial radiations.

The seer says that the visions are what makes the drones worship us, but the scientist believes otherwise. One of the drone models took on to the idea through a fast form of vocal communication, similar to chirps. We decide to take advantage of this development, by setting up farms to grow many copies of this model. We provide the food source in the form of grains, and the bipeds that once roamed willy nilly across the surface rooted themselves to one place, and started multiplying in droves. From that day onwards, we had them trapped right where they wanted. According to the doctor, the drones were blind enough to believe that it was their idea all along.

Eventually the bipeds started constructing slaves of their own, which worked for us. These were inelegant clankers made out of metal and burnt sand. We tried further enhancing the drones and making them increasingly autonomous by training their primitive minds, but our attempts did not have any spectacular results. They never managed to lose their dependence on us.

### 5 BILLION YEARS

The visions that we planted in their ancestors bore fruit in the biped drones, who saw dreams of going beyond their planets. Every star system eventually gets these pesky pioneers, a species that sits at the narrow bottom of the food chain, and thinks that